

PHLOEM A system of cells that carries nutrients throughout a plant.

PHOTOSYNTHESIS The process by which plants generate their own food, occurring when a green pigment called chlorophyll reacts with sunlight, carbon dioxide, and water to make carbohydrates, water, and oxygen.

PIGMENT A colored chemical used by plants to collect light. One pigment, chlorophyll, makes plants look green.

PLANTLET A young plant, which is sometimes attached to its parent.

PLUMULE The embryo shoot in a seed.

POLLEN Microscopic grains containing male sex cells. Pollen is produced by the anthers of flowers.

POLLINATION The process by which pollen is carried from one flower to another. The male pollen fertilizes the female ovule and creates a seed. Insects and animals often carry pollen between flowering plants, or it can be blown by the wind.

RECEPTACLE The part of a plant that contains the flower, or in flowerless plants, the reproductive organs or spores.

RHIZOME A creeping underground stem. Rhizomes often sprout leaves as they push their way through the ground.

ROOT The part of a plant that anchors it to a solid surface, such as soil, and absorbs water and nutrients.

RUNNER A stem that produces new plants by growing across the ground and sprouting roots.

Bamboo, a monocot plant



Poppy seeds scattered by the wind

SEED A tough structure used by plants to reproduce. A seed contains a young plant, or embryo, together with all the food reserves it needs to start life on its own.

SEPAL A leafy flap that protects a flower while it is still a bud. Sepals often fall off when the flower opens.

SHOOT The parts of a plant above ground, including its stems, leaves, and flowers.

SPADIX A fleshy spike of flowers.

SPATHE A leaflike hood that partly encloses a flowerhead.

SPECIES A group of plants, or other living things, that look similar, and that normally breed together in the wild.

SPORE A single-celled reproductive unit of some organisms.

SPUR A flowering or fruit-bearing branch that shoots out from an existing plant.

STAMEN The pollen-producing part of a flower, consisting of a filament and an anther.

STARCH The main food type stored in a plant. Chemically known as a carbohydrate, this food contains vital energy reserves.

STEM The part of a plant that carries the leaves. Also known as a stalk, the stem transports water and food from the roots to the rest of the plant.

STIGMA The structure in a flower that receives pollen during pollination.

STOMA An opening through which gases enter and leave the green part of a plant.

STYLE The stalklike structure in a flower that connects the stigma with the ovary.

TAPROOT A main root growing down.

TENDER A plant that is sensitive to the cold.

TENDRIL A threadlike part of a plant that grows outward and wraps around nearby objects, helping the plant to stay upright.

TEPAL A flap around a flower that performs the functions of both sepal and petal.

TESTA A hard shell or coating around a seed.



Variegated ivy leaf

TRANSPIRATION The movement of water through a plant. Water is taken up by the roots, and it evaporates through pores in the leaves.

TUBER A swelling or lump that forms in a root or stem and usually contains valuable food reserves for the rest of the plant. A potato is a tuber.

UMBEL An umbrella-shaped flowerhead.

VARIEGATED Streaked or mottled, with contrasting colors. In plants, variegated leaves are caused by differences in the pigments across the leaf.

VEGETATION The plants found in a particular habitat or environment.

WHORL A collection of leaves, sepals, or petals growing in a circle around a plant stem.

XYLEM A system of cells that carries water through a plant. In shrubs and trees, toughened xylem cells form wood.

ZYGOTE A fertilized egg.